



The BC Cancer Hereditary Cancer Program gives information and free genetic testing to people who may have inherited a higher chance to get cancer.

What is cancer?

Cancer happens in the body when cells grow too much. Genetic changes in cells can cause this to happen.

What is hereditary cancer?

Some people are born with gene changes that give them a higher chance to get cancer. These changes can be passed down in families. This is called hereditary cancer.

Is it common to have cancer in a family?

Yes. Cancer is very common. Most families will have some people with cancer. Age and environment are the main risk factors for most cancers.

Is hereditary cancer common?

No. Less than 10% of cancers are hereditary.

That means
less than 1 in 10
cancers are caused
by a gene change
that is passed on
in families.



What is genetic testing?

It is a blood test or a saliva test. It checks for changes in genes.

Genetic testing is free for people who may have an increased risk for hereditary cancer.

How is genetic testing helpful to you and your family?

- If a gene change **is** found, it is important information for you and your family. It may change the type of cancer treatment a person with cancer gets.
- For people who have not had cancer, finding a gene change gives those people more options to catch cancer early or prevent cancer.
- If a gene change is **not** found, this can be reassuring. Options to catch cancer early or prevent cancer can still be talked about with the Hereditary Cancer Program.



Who should get genetic testing?

Genetic testing is offered to people who have a higher chance for hereditary cancer. The Hereditary Cancer Program gives information and support to help people decide if they want to have testing. If people meet with us, it does not mean they have to test.

How do I get more information?

We can answer your questions or make an appointment for you with our team.

You do not need a referral from your doctor. You do not need to know everything about your family history of cancer.

We offer services to anyone living in BC or Yukon. You do not need to travel to meet with us.

Contact Us

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